...AND THOSE AGAINST IT



"WHEN BANNING MEAT SHOPS, WHY NOT BAN KFC TOO? MANY OF THESE BJP LEADERS ALSO RUN RESTAURANTS WHERE MEAT IS SERVED. WILL THEY SHUT THOSE DOWN? THEY WANT TO SHOW THEIR BRAVADO BY DESTROYING A POOR MAN'S FOOD CART"

SANJAY SINGH
AAP leader and Rajya Sabha MP

"The calls for meat bans reflect the duplicity of the Hindu right-wing. Hindutva icon Savarkar himself said that cow worship is superstition. Meat ban demands are just to put minorities in their place"



ABHISHEK CHOUDHARY
Author of Vajpayee: The Ascent of the Hindu Right

"IT'S A PROVEN FACT THAT OVER 70% OF INDIA IS NON-VEGETARIAN, SO THE VEGETARIAN HINDI-HINDU-MANUVADIS HAVE NO BUSINESS SHUTTING DOWN NON-VEG FOOD OUTLETS"



JAWAHAR SIRCAR
Ex-bureaucrat and ex-Rajya Sabha MP

A HIGHER CALLING

- Indologist N.P. Bhaduri says the Valmiki Ramayana, Mahabharata and the Puranas have references to meat consumption
- Scholar Lakshmanshastri Joshi's 'Hindudharma Samiksha' highlights instances where Vedic Gods are pleased with sacrifice of goats, horses and cows
- In Bengal, Maa Kali has historically been worshipped with meat offerings. In the old days, dacoits would offer a human sacrifice—Dakate Kali—before going on raids
- Maharashtra's warkari tradition refers to saint Sajan Kasai, who was a butcher and devotee of the sect's deity, Lord Vithoba
- Animal sacrifice and consuming the meat as food has been part of religious rituals across India, even at temples such as the Kamakhya (Assam), Kalighat (Kolkata) and Tulja Bhavani (Maharashtra)

'sale and purchase of meat in the open' has been banned along pilgrimage routes. Last year, a new order added another layer of tension—businesses and eateries along the yatra route were told to display the owners' names, which critics saw as a bid to single out Muslim establishments.

Beyond formal policy actions, UP has also been witnessing frequent incidents of vigilante justice. This is reflected in the educational spaces too. In 2016, the Baba Saheb Bhim Rao Ambedkar University (BBAU) in Lucknow banned non-vegetarian food in its mess despite students protesting the "anti-Dalit move", signalling institutional alignment with broader cultural pressures. Last year, the principal of a private school in Amroha suspended a nursery student for carrying non-vegetarian food in his lunchbox. The case drew widespread attention after a video posted by the child's mother went viral. In 2019, an FIR was filed against 43 people in Mahoba district for allegedly serving non-vegetarian biryani during an Urs without 'prior consent'.

Cow vigilantism, spearheaded by self-styled *gau rakshak*s, remains the most violent manifestation of anti-meat sentiment in the state. Often operating with impunity, their targets have predominantly been Muslims and Dalits suspected of cow slaughter or beef consumption. UP has seen several such episodes in the past decade, the most infamous being the lynching of Mohammad Akhlaq in Dadri in 2015 over rumours of beef possession.

Neighbouring Madhya Pradesh has been trying to keep up with UP on this front of late. The first order Chief Minister Mohan Yadav issued after taking office in December 2023 was to ban the sale of meat and fish in the open. The administration in various districts acted with alacrity on the orders of the newly appointed CM.

Small fishmongers who had set up temporary sites on pavements were chased away, and curtains began to appear on the entrances of meat shops. Municipal bodies dialled down the drive over the months, but meat shops remain in the government's crosshairs. From April 1, 2025, liquor shops have been shut in 19 towns of 'Hindu significance' in MP. Now, some right-wing groups also want a ban on the sale of meat in these towns.

Earlier, former chief minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan had been vehemently opposed to the introduction of eggs in children's diet at the anganwadis in the state, despite MP having some of the worst indices in malnutrition. The state has a 21 per cent tribal population that is mostly non-vegetarian, yet anganwadis in tribal areas still do not serve eggs—which nutritionists consider as the best and cheapest source of protein for children. Malnutrition is the highest among tribal communities in the state, compared to other groups.